ALISHER BATMANOV

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Graduate Coordinator:	Andrew Flores	aflores@ucsd.edu	(858) 534-1867

Education

2021–2027	**University of California San Diego** – Ph.D. Economics (expected)
2019–2021	**Central European University**, Austria – M.A. Economics, *summa cum laude*
2015–2019	**Nazarbayev University**, Kazakhstan – B.A. Economics, *magna cum laude*

Research Fields

Primary	Experimental Economics, Behavioral Economics
Secondary	Development Economics, Economic Theory

References

Emanuel Vespa (Co-chair)	Professor	Department of Economics	evespa@ucsd.edu
Isabel Trevino (Co-chair)	Associate Professor	Department of Economics	itrevino@ucsd.edu
Denis Shishkin	Assistant Professor	Department of Economics	dshishkin@ucsd.edu
Marta Serra-Garcia	Professor	Rady School of Management	mserragarcia@ucsd.edu
Melissa Famulari	Teaching Professor	Department of Economics	mfamulari@ucsd.edu

Relevant Positions

2025–present	Experimental Laboratory Manager at UC San Diego's EconLab
2024–present	UC San Diego Undergraduate–Graduate Economic Research Lab Supervisor

Job Market Paper

"Fragile Learning From Others" [pdf]

Behavioral biases in decision-making are widespread and often persist despite experience and transparent feedback. This paper examines whether exposure to others' optimal decisions can correct initial misconceptions and facilitate learning in an environment where departures from the theoretical benchmark arise from neglecting an informative signal in a worker hiring task. Using a laboratory experiment, I show that such exposure substantially improves the quality of one's own decisions. The analysis of the underlying mechanisms shows that this improvement is not driven by mechanical imitation, as responses to exposure are *asymmetric* in the quality of observed choices, pointing instead to selective adoption of observed behavior. Adopting others' decisions selectively, however, need not reflect an understanding of *why* those decisions are optimal, so I further evaluate the transfer of these learning gains to a modified environment once exposure ends. The main result of the paper is that learning from others is *fragile*: the improvements do not survive a change in the environment's primitives, and the acquired gains from exposure dissipate entirely. Comparing these effects with those of explicit guidance further underscores the limits of social exposure as an effective policy tool. These findings highlight the dual role of observational learning: while it can enhance the incidence of optimal behavior, the improvements it generates often fail to generalize beyond the observed context.

Working Papers

"Information versus Interpretation: Evidence from an Experiment on Persuasion"
(with Bridget Galaty) **[pdf]**

We experimentally study the relative persuasive effects of having more information versus having the same information but complementing the message with an explanation in a strategic communication environment. Senders recommend an action, and Receivers make a prediction based on a dataset they observe together with the Sender's recommendation. By varying the Sender's information and message format in a 2-by-2 design, we separate the effect of new information from that of new interpretation. We find that an informational advantage is the dominant channel: messages from better-informed Senders pull Receivers' guesses substantially closer to the recommendation, while adding an explanation to a message yields only a small insignificant effect, with or without an informational advantage. This asymmetry persists at every level of task difficulty. When the preferences of Senders and Receivers are aligned, information remains the stronger channel, though explanations now add marginal persuasive power. Consistent with these responses, when Receivers choose which type of message to receive, a majority prefer one from a better-informed Sender over one with an explanation, and the Receivers who prefer the explanation are the least responsive to information.

Published Papers

"Beliefs, Information Sharing, and Mental Health Care Use Among University Students"
(with Idaliya Grigoryeva, Bruno Calderón, Roberto González and Alejandro Guardiola) **[pdf]**

Journal of Development Economics (2026), 180, 103646.

This paper investigates the role of beliefs and stigma in shaping students' use of professional mental health services at a large private university in Mexico, where supply-side barriers are minimal and services are readily accessible. In a survey experiment with 680 students, we find that nearly 50% of students in distress do not receive professional mental health support despite a high level of awareness and perceived effectiveness, constituting a substantial treatment gap. We document stigmatized beliefs and misconceptions correlated with the treatment gap. As three-quarters of students incorrectly believe that those in distress perform worse academically and that the majority of students going to therapy are in severe distress, we implement an information intervention to correct these beliefs. We find that it increases students' sharing of on-campus mental health resources with peers and encourages them to recommend these resources when advising a friend in distress. Interestingly, we find that it lowers respondents' willingness to pay for private therapy at the end of the intervention. Yet, this effect does not translate into a long-run reduction in self-reported therapy use six months after the experiment, with prior therapy users showing increased off-campus take-up.

"Reproducibility and Robustness of Economics and Political Science Research"
(meta paper with Abel Brodeur, Derek Mikola, Nikolai Cook, et al.) **[pdf]**

Nature (2026), 652(8108), 151–156.

Work in Progress

"Learning to Ignore Irrelevant Contingencies: An Experiment"
(with Jeongbin Kim and Emanuel Vespa) *(draft coming soon!)*

Identifying and discarding irrelevant contingencies is a crucial component of theoretical analysis. A contingency may be irrelevant because it occurs with probability zero or because the agent's payoff is unaffected by their choice. While the literature has documented that people often struggle to ignore irrelevant contingencies, it remains unclear whether difficulties with learning to ignore them depend on what makes them irrelevant. In this paper, we design an experiment to address this question. Our main finding is that participants are more likely to learn to ignore probability-zero contingencies than contingencies in which their payoff is independent of their choice.

"Descriptive Simplicity in Strategyproof Matching Mechanisms" *(designing experiment)*

Although strategyproof matching mechanisms such as deferred acceptance (DA) and serial dictatorship (SD) guarantee that straightforward reporting is a dominant strategy, empirical evidence consistently documents widespread deviations from truthful behavior. This raises a fundamental question: are such deviations driven by strategic incentives, or by misunderstanding of the mechanism's informational structure? In this project, I examine whether alternative descriptions of strategyproof mechanisms can reduce cognitive burden and improve straightforward reporting. Rather than altering the underlying mechanism, I focus on how it is explained to participants. Specifically, I study interventions that highlight counterfactual outcomes under alternative rank-order lists, allowing participants to observe for themselves that strategizing cannot improve their payoff. By making the logic of strategyproofness transparent through concrete examples, the intervention aims to improve participants' understanding of dominant-strategy incentives and increase truthful reporting.

"Learning About Therapy From Friends: Conversations & Treatment Take-Up Among Students"
(with Idaliya Grigoryeva) *(designing experiment)*

Many university students in mental distress do not seek professional help, even where counseling is free and widely regarded as effective. Information interventions that correct misperceptions about therapy have been shown to increase conversations about mental health and the sharing of resources among peers, yet their effects on individual help-seeking remain limited. In this project, we ask whether learning from friends' therapy-use experience can shift help-seeking itself. We propose a field experiment at a large university with free on-campus counseling, in which students attend small group sessions with their peers. In treated groups, a structured conversation invites participants to share how they or people close to them came to seek therapy and what the experience was like, while control groups discuss an unrelated campus topic. Our primary outcome is subsequent use of counseling services. To our knowledge, this is the first experiment to test whether learning from the lived experiences of peers moves students from talking about mental health to seeking care.

Teaching at UC San Diego

For a summary of my teaching evaluations with department benchmarks, see **[pdf]**.

Course Instructor

Intermediate Econometrics (ECON-120B) — FA25
Student learning: 4.54/5 | Course structure: 4.52/5 | Class environment: 4.77/5

Intermediate Microeconomics (ECON-100A) — SU25
Student learning: 4.60/5 | Course structure: 4.60/5 | Class environment: 4.65/5

Intermediate Econometrics (ECON-120B) — SU24
Student learning: 4.24/5 | Course structure: 4.36/5 | Class environment: 4.64/5

Teaching Assistant

Intermediate Microeconomics (ECON-100A), for Prof. Grigoryan — SP26
Overall rating: 4.79/5 | Positive responses: 98%

Principles of Microeconomics (ECON-1), for Prof. Famulari — SU24, FA22
Overall rating: 4.78/5 | Positive responses: 96%

Game Theory (ECON-109), for Profs. Watson and Shishkin — SU26, SU25, WI24, FA23, SU23
Overall rating: 4.66/5 | Positive responses: 94%

Intermediate Microeconomics (ECON-100B), for Prof. Grigoryan — SP24, SU23
Overall rating: 4.63/5 | Positive responses: 97%

Experiments in Firms (MGT-160), for Profs. Sadoff, Samek, and Fragiadakis — FA24, WI25, SP25
Overall rating: 4.63/5 | Positive responses: 95%

Behavioral Economics (ECON-142), for Prof. Trevino SP23
Overall rating: 4.50/5 | Positive responses: 100%

Econometrics (ECON-220B, PhD level), for Prof. Ma WI23
Overall rating: 4.90/5 | Positive responses: 98%

Conference Presentations

2026	Economic Science Association (ESA) North American Meetings, *Charlottesville VA*
	Stanford Institute for Theoretical Economics (SITE-Experimental), *Stanford*
	Behavioral & Experimental Workshop in Theory-Based Experiments (CTESS), *Caltech*
	Economic Science Association (ESA) World Meetings, *Los Angeles CA*
	Southwest Economic Theory Conference (SWET), *Loyola Marymount University*
2025	Behavioral Economics Annual Meeting (BEAM), *UC Berkeley* (participant)
	Economic Science Association (ESA) North American Meetings, *Tucson AZ*
	Los Angeles Experiments (LAX) Conference, *UCLA* (participant)
	Behavioral & Experimental Economics Student Conference, *UC Santa Barbara*
	Advances with Field Experiments (AFE) Conference, *University of Chicago*
	American Economic Association (AEA) CSQIEP Mentoring Conference, *Chicago IL*
2024	Economic Science Association (ESA) North American Meetings, *Columbus OH*
	Behavioral & Experimental Economics Student Conference, *Caltech*
	Los Angeles Experiments (LAX) Conference, *Caltech* (poster)
2023	Behavioral & Experimental Economics Student Conference, *Caltech*

Schools & Workshops

2026	Russell Sage Foundation (RSF) Summer Institute in Behavioral Economics, *Boston MA*
2025	Chicago School in Experimental Economics (CSEE), *University of Chicago*
2024	Learning, Computational and Bayesian Methods in Experimental Economics, *Purdue*
	Rady Spring School in Behavioral Economics, *UC San Diego*
2023	Summer Institute in Theory-Based Experiments (CTESS), *Caltech*

Research Grants

2023–2024	The Weiss Fund for Research in Development Economics
2024	UC-Mexico Alianza Short-Term Research Stay in Mexico
2024	Institute for Humane Studies – Conference Accelerator Grant
2021	Foundation of Budapest Research Grant, Central European University

Fellowships & Awards

2024	Diversity Research Fellowship, UC San Diego
2021–2022	Regents and Summer Research Fellowship, UC San Diego

2021 Peter Hangartner Prize and Fellowship, Central European University

2019 Outstanding Student in Economics Award, Nazarbayev University

Refereeing

Economic Journal, *Games and Economic Behavior*, *Journal of Development Economics*

Languages

Kazakh (native), English (fluent), Russian (fluent)

Software Skills

Python, Stata, Matlab, Julia, oTree, JavaScript

Last updated on October 15, 2026